HD Point, report, Landscape, Africa, 2026-10-30

AI on African farms: advice by SMS, satellites overhead and a low-adoption warning

Key figures

Figure	Value	Basis	Claim
iShamba farmers	1.2 million farmers	Verified	c9

What was reported

1. A 2026 systematic review of AI in East African agriculture identifies five main application areas: advisory services, precision agriculture, crop and pest monitoring, financial and market intelligence, and climate-smart agriculture. **Verified** c1
2. The review finds that adoption of AI among smallholder farmers in East Africa remains relatively low and uneven. **Verified** c2
3. It reports that in parts of East Africa, farmers using digital and AI-supported advisory services reported better crop management, increased yields and reduced input waste. **Verified** c3
4. Kenya leads in AI use among smallholder farmers, while Ethiopia shows the lowest adoption, which the review links to access to smartphones and digital agricultural services. **Verified** c4
5. Kenyan smallholders use tools including PlantVillage+ and Virtual Agronomist to get real-time advice on pest control, fertiliser use and crop disease detection. **Verified** c5
6. A data scientist quoted by iAfrica says mobile tools such as WhatsApp bots could give smallholders real-time agronomic advice and address a shortage of agricultural extension officers. **Company says** c6
7. In Ghana and Nigeria, SMS-based AI systems give localised advice on planting dates, fertiliser use and pest control, and the magazine says farmers reported yield increases of between 30% and 50% when advice was combined with quality inputs. **Company says** c7
8. Nigeria's National Space Research and Development Agency, working with the Ministry of Agriculture, analyses satellite imagery every five days to map farm boundaries, monitor crop health and forecast national harvests months ahead. **Verified** c8

9. Kenya's iShamba farmer helpline serves more than 1.2 million farmers through text and voice services. **Verified** c9
10. A Food and Agriculture Organization event brought together three young AI entrepreneurs from Zimbabwe, Nigeria and Kenya who support smallholder farmers, and highlighted that digital inclusion is essential for rural communities. **Verified** c10
11. Femi Adekoya of Integrated Aerial Precision in Nigeria uses drones and AI to promote precision agriculture, according to the FAO. **Verified** c11
12. Opportunity International signed with Safaricom to bring an AI chatbot, FarmerAI, to Kenya, piloting with potato farmers through DigiFarm, according to AVODA Group. **Verified** c12

How well sourced is this?

10 of 12 claims are supported by an independent source. 2 come from the company itself and have not been independently checked.

Source	Claims	Basis
https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1155/tswj/5128133	c1, c2, c3, c4	Verified
https://iafrica.com/kenyan-smallholder-farmers-use-ai-apps-to-detect-crop-disease-and-cut-costs-as-agritech-spreads-across-africa/	c5, c6	Verified, Company says
https://www.africanleadershipmagazine.co.uk/ai-and-africas-farms-closing-the-yield-gap-sustainably/	c7, c8, c9	Company says, Verified
https://www.fao.org/africa/news-stories/news-detail/young-african-agripreneurs-share-ai-solutions-for-agrifood-systems-transformation/en	c10, c11	Verified
https://avodagroup.org/ai-agro-dealers-last-mile-agriculture/	c12	Verified

About this report

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